

# Avoidance and Engagement: Issue Competition in Multiparty Systems

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A substantial literature claims that political parties compete over issues by selectively emphasizing favorable issues and avoiding issues emphasized by their opponents. In recent years, this understanding of issue competition has been challenged by empirical studies showing issue engagement to be the rule rather than the exception. To move the discussion beyond the descriptive question about degree of issue avoidance or issue engagement, this article offers a theoretical framework of issue competition that addresses central but hitherto neglected questions about which parties respond to which parties. The main implications of the theoretical framework are tested in a set of statistical time-series analyses of party interaction in Denmark covering more than 50 years, 24 major issues and 21 elections. These analyses offer support to the ideas that parties are more responsive to the issue agendas of parties from their own party family than to the issue agendas of non-family parties and that large mainstream parties are more responsive than niche parties to the common issue agenda of the other parties in the party system.

**Keywords:** issue competition; agenda-setting; party competition

Do political parties respond to the attention their competitors pay to issues or do they ignore each other, selectively focusing on their own preferred issues? In other words, do some parties, for instance, talk about immigration and European integration whereas others talk about the economy? Though most scholars acknowledge that parties do respond to their competitors' attention to issues, the dominant theoretical accounts (e.g. Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996; Riker, 1996; Robertson, 1976; Simon, 2002) have had much more to say about ignorance and selective issue emphases than about issue engagement and responsiveness.

This one-sided theoretical focus is of course justified if strongly supported by empirical observations. The problem is, however, that many recent empirical studies report issue engagement in political campaigns to be the rule rather than the exception (see, e.g., Kaplan *et al.*, 2006; Sides, 2006; Sigelman and Buell, 2004). Consequently, questions about issue convergence and issue engagement need theoretical consideration to bring the literature further towards an understanding of which parties respond to which parties in issue competition.

In this paper, we present a framework that includes the dual importance of both a distinct and relatively stable party specific component in a party's issue attention profile as well as a common party system agenda component. While the idea of a party-specific component is consistent with well-known ideas about selective issue emphases (Budge and Farlie, 1983), issue ownership (Petrocik, 1996; Simon, 2002) and the dominance/dispersion principle (Riker, 1996), the idea of a common agenda component is inspired by the neighboring literature on agenda-setting (Jones and Baumgartner, 2005; McCombs, 2004).

The framework takes its point of departure in a multiparty context and empirically we draw on time-series data from the Danish multiparty system covering the issue emphases of all political parties participating in national Danish elections between 1953 and 2007. As noted by Adams and Somer-Topcu (2009, p. 829), the multiparty context is clearly the one most parties in the Western world find themselves in and therefore a natural point of departure.

The empirical analysis produces four important conclusions. First, in line with the dominant theoretical perspective on issue competition we find a strong, stable and party-specific component in parties' issue attention profile. Second, however, the analysis also shows that political parties do adjust their issue attention in response to (lagged) changes in other parties' issue attention. Third, the analysis reveals a distinct 'party family effect' in the sense that parties are more responsive to the issue campaigns of parties from the same party family than those from other parties. It is important to stress, however, that parties still respond to the issue attention of parties from another party family. Thus, the finding that parties respond to other parties' issue agenda is not just driven by the fact that some of these parties belong to the same party family. Fourth and finally, the analysis shows how large, mainstream parties are particularly responsive to the issue agenda of the other parties in the party system.

### Issue Competition and Party Interaction

The idea of issue competition has been well established in political science since David Robertson (1976). He argued that party competition is focused on selective emphasis rather than direct confrontation – an argument that was further developed in Ian Budge and Dennis Farlie's (1983) selective emphasis thesis and in John Petrocik's (1996) issue ownership theory. The issue competition idea also formed the basis of the ambitious Comparative Party Manifesto (CMP) Project (see Budge *et al.*, 2001). However, as the research emerging from the party manifesto tradition exemplifies, the literature on issue competition has been slow to move beyond the idea that parties have issues they prefer to the question of how parties with different issue preferences interact.

The puzzle is that empirical studies of the issue attention of electoral competitors systematically show considerable issue overlap. Studies of American presidential campaigns and congressional elections find considerable issue overlap (Damore, 2004; Sides, 2006; Sigelman and Buell, 2004), as do studies of the election manifestos of political parties in Western Europe (Green-Pedersen, 2007). Hence, although political competitors may prefer to focus exclusively on certain issues, the reality is that they show a high degree of similarity in their issue emphases. The literature on issue competition has very little to say about this interaction and therefore ends up having surprisingly little to say about how parties compete over issues (see also Meguid, 2005; Tavits, 2008, p. 51).

To advance our understanding of issue *competition* we need to start by recognizing that a party's issue strategies are constrained and influenced by the activities of other political parties. From this starting point we can begin to actually investigate issue competition – i.e. address questions about who is more influenced by other parties and which parties react to which parties.

### Issue Competition in a Multiparty Context

A framework of issue competition in a multiparty context can be outlined by thinking of parties' issue attention as driven by two basic components: A *party-specific component* and an *agenda component*. The first component reflects the issue preferences of the party and is driven by specific party characteristics such as the party's historical issue ownership or ideology. There are certain issues they want to stress more than others and certain issues they tend to ignore, and these issue preferences vary somewhat across parties but are relatively stable over time. Social democratic parties, for instance, typically own an issue like the welfare state (Ross, 2000), which again is closely related to the party's ideology, and this ownership has – exactly because of its linkage with ideology – persisted over a long time (Walgrave and De Swert, 2007). This leads us to expect stability in the issue attention of political parties over time. This idea is captured by our first hypothesis labeled the 'party component hypothesis':

H1: Every party shows a strong continuity in its issue attention which is distinct from the issue attention of other parties in the party system.

The other basic component is the *agenda component*. At any given time, a hierarchy of issues exists which constrains the parties. To understand this agenda component and thus why parties respond to each other, we draw on the concept of the 'party system agenda' developed by Christoffer Green-Pedersen and Peter Mortensen (2010). From this perspective, agenda-setting processes are systemic in the sense that agendas are influenced by actors, but at the same time influence the issues actors address. When issues rise on the agenda, actors have a strong incentive to pay attention to them even as they compete about the future content of the agenda, and when issues drop off the agenda again parties are relieved to address other issues that are rising on the common party system agenda. The existence of a party system agenda is thus due to the perceptions across all parties that certain issues are more important than others.

From an agenda-setting perspective, ignoring the party system agenda may be a difficult and risky strategy for a party. It is difficult for parties to completely ignore issues that other parties talk about because there are institutionalized debates in, for instance, parliaments, where attention to an issue is unavoidable. In the same way, the media will approach parties and ask for their positions on issues to which other parties pay attention. Furthermore, ignoring an issue is potentially dangerous because a party then loses influence on how it is framed in the public debate when the party might later have to address it (Jerit, 2008). If a party has been successful in shaping the party system agenda, the party-specific component and the agenda component may work in the same direction – e.g. this is probably the case for social democrats, for instance, if the issue of the welfare state is placed high on the party system agenda. However, a central finding in studies of agenda-setting is that no one has the capacity to control an agenda like the party system agenda (see Kingdon, 1995). Hence the expectation is that the party component and the agenda component show distinguishable effects and we expect the issue attention of a party at a given time to be influenced by the issue attention of the other parties in the party system. This can be summarized in the following hypothesis labeled the 'agenda component hypothesis':

H2: A party's issue attention is influenced by the issue agenda of all other parties in the party system.

A theoretical framework that incorporates both the party and the agenda components is a significant contribution to the literature. However, it is also only a first step towards an understanding of when and why parties engage in or avoid issues. The next hypotheses are focused on the conditionality of engagement/avoidance. Since theoretical accounts of issue competition have tended to focus exclusively on the incentives to ignore each other, the following extensions pay particular attention to the agenda component in order to further develop our understanding of parties' responses to other parties.

First, James Adams and Zeynep Somer-Topcu (2009) have shown that in terms of positional policy shifts, parties are more responsive to parties from the same ideological party family (see also Vliegenhart *et al.*, 2011). For instance, social democratic parties respond more to positional shifts from other left-wing parties than to positional shifts from right-wing parties. For several reasons, we expect a similar dynamic in issue competition. Parties from the same party family or party bloc are likely to have relatively similar issue preferences. The issues that, say, social democrats favor are likely to be relatively similar to what other left-wing parties favor (Walgrave and De Swert, 2007, pp. 42–7). This provides them with a common interest in focusing on these issues. Furthermore, in a multiparty system parties from the same party bloc are also likely to be coalition partners with regard to, say, government formation. To present themselves as a credible government alternative, parties wanting to form a government coalition need to appear homogenous and thus focus on similar issues. This leads to the third hypothesis, which we label the 'party bloc hypothesis':

H3: A party's issue attention is *more responsive* to the issue attention of parties from the same party bloc than to the issue attention of parties that do not belong to the same party bloc.

It is important to stress that this hypothesis does not imply that parties only respond to issue attention from parties from the same party bloc. A core element in showing the importance of the party system agenda is to show that it does not just result from a party responding to the issue attention of parties belonging to the same party bloc. Given that parties belonging to the same party bloc to some extent share issue ownership, responsiveness to the issue emphases of other parties within the bloc may be consistent with a broad interpretation of the selective issue emphases argument. Responsiveness, however, to the issue attention of parties from the other bloc seems incompatible with the theoretical arguments behind the selective issue emphasis hypothesis. Hence, the perhaps strongest claim derived from our proposed framework of issue competition is the 'non-party bloc hypothesis':

H4: A party's issue attention is influenced by the issue attention of parties that do not belong to the same party bloc.

The literature on spatial or positional competition has increasingly focused on the difference between what are known as 'mainstream parties' and 'niche parties' (Ezrow, 2008; Meguid, 2005). Mainstream parties – or catch-all parties – include Labour/Social Democrats, Conservatives and/or Liberals, which have typically dominated government formation and have drawn the most electoral support. Niche parties, on the other hand, are

smaller parties that seek votes from a more delineated sub-segment of the electorate and hence benefit from a more distinct issue attention profile (Wagner, 2012).

In terms of issue competition, the party and agenda components are expected to play a different role for the two types of party. Niche parties have a few issues they focus upon and this is most likely relatively stable from election to election. Green parties, for instance, focus permanently on the environment. The enduring party component is therefore likely to be a more prominent characteristic of these parties than for large mainstream parties. The latter type of party, on the other hand, has a much broader and flexible issue appeal, though they also have preferred issues. Mainstream parties need to be closely aligned with the broader party system agenda to maintain their pivotal role and support in the electorate. Therefore, the issue attention profiles of mainstream parties are probably closer to the average issue agenda of the party system than are other parties' issue attention profiles. This is summarized in the following 'mainstream party hypothesis':

H5: Mainstream parties are more influenced by the party system agenda and show less continuity in their issue attention than other parties.

These hypotheses are the main focus of the following analysis. Many more implications may be derived from the theoretical framework, however, including potential differences between opposition and government parties as well as different responses to main competitors versus potential future coalition partners. To the extent the research design allows us to look into these aspects, we return to these dynamics in the latter part of the analysis.

## Data and Variables

In order to examine the hypotheses about issue competition in a multiparty system we investigate issue competition in Denmark since 1953. Denmark has a multiparty system where typically 8–10 parties run for election and 6–8 parties gain representation in parliament. Denmark is thus a relatively typical example of a multiparty system and thus well suited for testing the hypotheses on issue competition derived above. Of more importance, however, choosing Denmark enables us to draw on recently developed datasets that cover not only election campaigns (party manifestos) that have typically been studied in relation to issue competition, but also annual measures of party competition between elections (parliamentary activities). The Danish case thus offers an opportunity to move the discussion of issue competition beyond what goes on in election campaigns.

### *Measuring Issue Attention in Party Manifestos*

The first dataset consists of the Danish party manifestos collected as part of the international party manifesto project supplemented by manifestos from recent elections.<sup>1</sup> The dataset covers 21 elections between 1953 and 2007. The Danish party manifestos have been recoded with the coding system of the Danish Policy Agendas Project (see <http://www.agendasetting.dk>), which is based on the Policy Agendas coding scheme originally developed by Baumgartner and Jones (1993) to study agenda setting in an American context.<sup>2</sup> Table A1 in the Appendix provides an overview of the 24 major issue categories such as macro-economy, health, energy, environment and immigration. Hence, for each Danish party running for election between 1953 and 2007, the manifesto dataset provides

a unique measure of the party's issue attention measured over 24 major issues at the time of the election, which will be used to construct the dependent variable for the analyses.

We begin by calculating each *party's issue attention* by dividing the number of sentences devoted to each of the 24 issues by the total number of sentences in the manifesto.<sup>3</sup> With this coding we not only obtain a measure of our dependent variable, but when lagged one election period it can also be used to estimate the extent of intraparty continuity in issue attention from election to election.<sup>4</sup>

For each consecutive election between 1953 and 2007 the manifesto dataset also allows us to calculate a common *party system agenda* representing the average issue attention of all other parties participating in the given election. For instance, if five parties – A, B, C, D and E – participate in an election, then the party system agenda facing Party A on issue *i* is calculated as the average attention to issue *i* of parties B, C, D and E, and this calculation has been repeated for each party in each election and for all 24 issues. This measure of a party system agenda facing a given party at the previous election can thus be used to estimate the importance of the party system agenda for a party's issue attention at a given election (the use of time lags is elaborated and justified below).

### ***Categorization of Bloc Parties and Mainstream Parties***

The party system agenda can be divided into a party bloc agenda and a non-bloc agenda to test the hypotheses about a party being more responsive to the issue attention of parties from the same party bloc. The parties in the Danish multiparty system are divided into two rather stable blocs competing for government power (Green-Pedersen and Thomsen, 2005).<sup>5</sup> One bloc consists of the two major center-right parties, the Conservatives and the Liberals, supported by the right-wing parties and often a couple of minor center-right parties. The other bloc consists of the Social Democrats supported by the other left-wing parties and typically also the Social Liberals. Except for the Social Democratic/Liberal government from 1978 to 1979, Danish governments have never crossed the blocs. The three center parties, Social Liberals, Christian Democrats and Centre Democrats, have sometimes changed blocs but the parties have always indicated before the election which bloc they would support in terms of government formation.

Empirically, we use this bloc grouping to divide the parties into a left- and right-wing party bloc. The reason is that it captures exactly the logic behind the party bloc hypothesis that a party due to its history and ideology is linked to certain parties in terms of similar issue preferences and in terms of standing together as a coalition. The three center parties were grouped with the bloc they supported at the relevant elections.

In order to examine the two hypotheses about the moderating effect of party type we constructed a dummy variable taking the value '1' if the party is one of the three, historically large mainstream parties in Denmark (the Social Democrats, the Conservatives or the Liberals); other parties were coded '0'. Ideally, a more fine-grained categorization of parties might be preferable, but such an approach would require a larger sample of parties. Therefore, the main analysis is conducted based on the simple distinction between mainstream parties and other parties, but later we explore in more detail to what extent alternative categorizations would change our substantive conclusions.

### ***Length of Debates in Parliament as an Alternative Measure of the Party System Agenda***

The time between elections is a limitation of measuring the party system agenda or the agenda component by coding of manifesto data only.<sup>6</sup> To address this limitation, we draw on a second dataset going back to 1953 measuring issue attention in the Danish parliament between elections. This measure is based on the length of debates in the Danish parliament (measured in columns in the annual records of parliament). Debates in parliament concern four activities – namely bills, governmental policy accounts, interpellations and parliamentary motions. The first two types of activity are government-driven and the latter two opposition-driven, and they balance each other rather closely in terms of the number of columns in the dataset stemming from government- and opposition-initiated activities, respectively (Mortensen, 2006, pp. 69–72).

A further advantage of using length of parliamentary debates as a measure of the common party system agenda is that it is not driven by the activities of a single or a few parties. Long debates about an interpellation or a bill arise in parliament because many parties find it important to address an issue. This, however, is also the limitation of this measure of the party system agenda. Whereas a party manifesto reflects a decision by the various parties in terms of how much attention they should pay to different issues, the length of a debate emerges as a result of the exchange between parties. This makes it an attractive measure of the party system agenda, but not of the selective issue attention of individual parties.<sup>7</sup> Therefore, in the first part of the following analysis we choose to draw on the party manifestos dataset only, and then in the second part we include the parliamentary dataset as an important robustness check on the findings regarding H1, H2 and H5. The topic of each parliamentary debate was coded based on the same system as the recoded CMP data, which makes the matching of the two datasets straightforward.

### **Model Specification and Analysis**

As argued by Adams and Somer-Topcu (2009, pp. 830–2), modeling the reciprocal influence of political parties on each other – i.e. party competition – is a major methodological challenge exactly because of the reciprocal influence. How does one determine that attention to issue *i* of party A at time *t* is influenced by attention to issue *i* of Party B at time *t* and not the other way around?

Inspired by Adams and Somer-Topcu (2009) the idea of causality guiding our modeling of issue competition is that we only allow for lagged explanatory variables in order to speak about causality. To the extent that we miss concurrent relationships, this only biases our test against finding statistically significant effects (see Adams and Somer-Topcu, 2009). Hence, while this statistical model specification improves our test of causality, it most probably generates conservative estimates of the effects.

Whereas Adams and Somer-Topcu (2009) in their study of party position shifts use *change* variables, we decide to use *levels* of issue attention in our statistical estimation. Parties' issue attention is likely to be rather dynamic and hence it does not seem likely that changes in the agenda from time *t*–1 to time *t* are a function of changes in the agenda from time *t*–2 to time *t*–1 since time *t*–2 will often take place 6–8 years before time *t*. Furthermore, using changes will make it impossible to assess the empirical validity of H1.<sup>8</sup>

A number of control variables have been tried out, such as the effective number of parties in the election, seat shares of the largest party, measures of party polarization, annual measures of GDP, length of manifestos and absolute length of debates in parliament. It turns out, however, that inclusion of these measures does not change any of the effects of main interest and are therefore left out of the analyses presented below.<sup>9</sup> The fact that we do not include exogenous issue specific factors like real world events does not imply that the lagged party variables are the only factors relevant to issue competition or that political parties develop issues out of the blue. Undoubtedly, parties sometimes simply react to commonly perceived outside events. While measures of such exogenous influences may be constructed for a very limited range of issues and years, they cannot in any meaningful way be taken into account when we look at the parties' attention to 24 major issues over a period of more than 50 years as we do in this study. On the other hand, when we look at the entire agenda space of Danish politics across half a century, any such effects for a given issue area ought to be idiosyncratic. Consequently, if we identify effects across the large number of elections, parties and issues covered here, this is strong evidence that such effects are systematic (for a similar multi-issue research strategy, see Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2010; Jones and Baumgartner, 2005; Vlieghenart *et al.*, 2011).

The five hypotheses derived above can now be translated into a set of testable propositions. First, our initial specification is:

$$\text{issue attention}(i, p, t) = b_1 + b_2[\text{issue attention}(i, p, t-1)] + b_3[\text{agenda}(i, p, t-1)] \quad (1)$$

where *issue attention*(i, p, t) is the share of the focal party p's manifesto devoted to issue category i at the current election time t; *issue attention*(i, p, t-1) is the share of the focal party p's manifesto devoted to issue category i at the previous election t-1; and *agenda*(i, p, t-1) is the average share of all parties' (except the focal party p) manifestos devoted to issue category i at the previous election t-1.

Second, we decompose the agenda effect into the agenda of parties from the same bloc as the focal party, and the agenda of parties from the other bloc than the focal party. We do so in order to investigate H3 and H4:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{issue attention}(i, p, t) = & b_1 + b_2[\text{issue attention}(i, p, t-1)] \\ & + b_4[\text{agenda bloc parties}(i, p, t-1)] \\ & + b_5[\text{agenda non-bloc parties}(i, p, t-1)] \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

where *agenda bloc parties*(i, p, t-1) is the average share of all bloc parties' (excluding the focal party p) manifesto devoted to issue category i at election t-1; and *agenda non-bloc parties*(i, p, t-1) is the average share of sentences devoted to issue category i at election t-1 in manifestos from parties belonging to the other bloc than the focal party.

Finally, to address the importance of distinguishing between mainstream parties and other parties (H5), we estimate the following equation:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{issue attention}(i, p, t) = & b_1 + b_2[\text{issue attention}(i, p, t-1)] \\ & + b_3[\text{agenda}(i, p, t-1)] + b_6[\text{party type}] \\ & + b_7[\text{party type} \times \text{issue attention}(i, p, t-1)] \\ & + b_8[\text{party type} \times \text{agenda}(i, p, t-1)] \end{aligned} \quad (3)$$

**Table 1: Overview of Hypotheses 1–5**

| <i>Name of hypothesis</i>           |                       |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| H1: The party component hypothesis  | $b_2 > 0$             |
| H2: The agenda component hypothesis | $b_3 > 0$             |
| H3: The bloc party hypothesis       | $b_4 > b_5$           |
| H4: The non-bloc party hypothesis   | $b_5 > 0$             |
| H5: The mainstream party hypothesis | $b_7 < 0$ & $b_8 > 0$ |

where *party type* is coded ‘1’ if mainstream party, otherwise ‘0’; *party type*  $\times$  *issue attention* (*i*, *p*, *t*–1) is an interaction term between the type of party and the focal party’s attention at the previous election as defined above; and *party type*  $\times$  *agenda* (*i*, *p*, *t*–1) is an interaction term between the type of party and the campaign agenda at the previous election as defined above.

Based on these expressions of the issue competition model, Table 1 provides an overview of H1–H5 in terms of what to expect from the estimable parameters in Equations 1–3.

In the following analysis we estimate Equations 1–3. Note that our dataset structure includes several layers (election times, parties, manifestos and issues) which may be considered as groups or clusters of data. This might suggest a rather cumbersome multilevel estimation with issues nested in manifestos nested in political parties that are nested in time (see, e.g., Vliegenhart and Walgrave, 2011). However, since initial multilevel explorations reveal intraclass correlations (IC) approaching 0 at the manifesto, party and election time levels, we decided to continue with a more parsimonious random effects model with varying intercepts for each issue category.<sup>10,11</sup> Furthermore, the use of relative shares may suggest a tobit estimation, but in fact censoring (left or right) is not a major problem in these data and hence we continue with a more conventional and simple approach.<sup>12</sup>

## Findings

Table 2 shows the empirical results relating to H1–H5. First, as a baseline model for comparison, model 1 in Table 2 is estimated with the issue attention of a given party at the previous election as well as the average issue attention of all the other parties in the previous election. This estimation provides initial support for both H1 and H2. The coefficient for the issue attention of a given party at the previous election is positive and clearly statistically significant ( $b_2 > 0$ ), which corroborates the idea of a rather stable party-specific component in parties’ issue attention – a distinct effect in the sense that it is not controlled out by the inclusion of a measure of the other parties’ issue agenda. Furthermore, consistent with H2, model 1 in Table 2 shows a strong common component in parties’ issue attention. As expected, the average issue attention of other parties at the previous election shows a positive and clearly statistically significant effect on the individual parties’ issue attentions at current elections ( $b_3 > 0$ ). This makes sense from an agenda-setting perspective, but challenges the standard view on issue competition that parties to a large extent ignore each other and attend to widely different issues.

**Table 2: Statistical Analyses of Parties' Issue Attention**

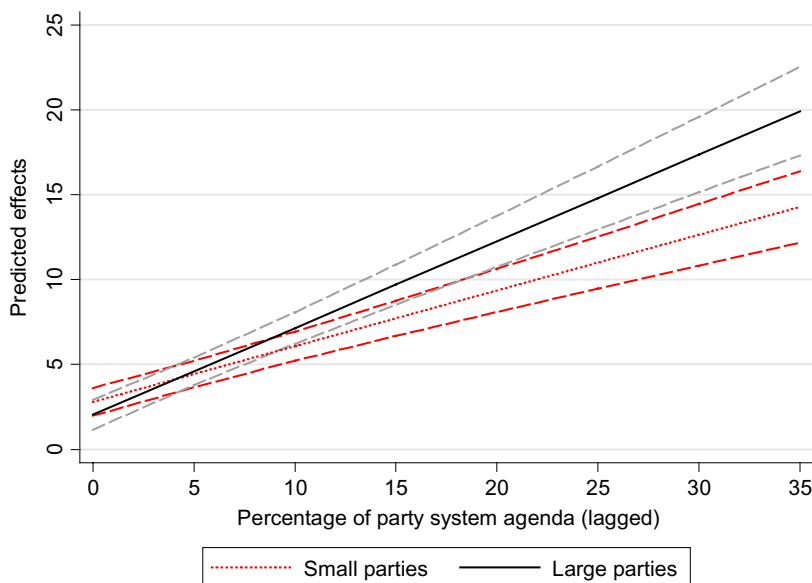
|                                                 |                   | <i>Model 1</i> | <i>Model 2</i> | <i>Model 3</i> |
|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|
| Constant                                        | [b <sub>1</sub> ] | 1.38*** (0.39) | 1.35*** (0.39) | 1.57*** (0.42) |
| Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>              | [b <sub>2</sub> ] | 0.28*** (0.02) | 0.24*** (0.02) | 0.29*** (0.02) |
| Agenda <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>                       | [b <sub>3</sub> ] | 0.39*** (0.03) | —              | 0.33*** (0.03) |
| Agenda bloc parties <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>          | [b <sub>4</sub> ] | —              | 0.33*** (0.02) | —              |
| Agenda non-bloc parties <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>      | [b <sub>5</sub> ] | —              | 0.10*** (0.02) | —              |
| Party type (mainstream = 1, others = 0)         | [b <sub>6</sub> ] | —              | —              | −0.47* (0.24)  |
| Party type × Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-1</sub> | [b <sub>7</sub> ] | —              | —              | −0.07* (0.03)  |
| Party type × Agenda <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>          | [b <sub>8</sub> ] | —              | —              | 0.18*** (0.04) |
| Level 1 N (issue)                               |                   | 24             | 24             | 24             |
| Variance Level 1                                |                   | 1.79           | 1.71           | 1.85           |
| N Total                                         |                   | 3,666          | 3,666          | 3,666          |

*Note:* Coefficients are unstandardized results from a restricted maximum likelihood multilevel random effects model. Standard errors in parentheses.  $b_1$ – $b_8$  are the estimated equivalents to the parameters in Equations 1–3 above (see also overview of hypotheses in Table 1). \* $p < 0.05$ . \*\* $p < 0.01$ . \*\*\* $p < 0.001$  (two-sided).

Model 2 in Table 2 shows the results of splitting the common agenda variable into the party bloc agenda variable and the non-bloc agenda variable. The model shows that parties respond much more to parties from their own party bloc than to the issue attention of parties from the other party bloc ( $b_4 > b_5$ ).<sup>13</sup> It also shows that parties respond to the issue attention from parties that are not bloc members ( $b_5 > 0$ ). In other words, the finding that parties respond to other parties is not just a matter of them responding to parties that belong to the same group or coalition of parties. They also respond to other parties, which is further evidence of a common agenda component in issue competition even between parties belonging to different party blocs.

Model 3 in Table 2 empirically examines H5 about the difference between mainstream and other parties. Based on the categorization of party types discussed in the section on data and variables, we add a dummy variable distinguishing between large mainstream parties (1) and other parties (0) and interact it with both the lagged agenda variable and the lagged dependent variable. The effect of the latter interaction term is expected to be negative – implying less intraparty continuity in large mainstream parties' issue attention – while the presence of a mainstream party, on the other hand, is expected to increase the effect of the common agenda compared to other parties.

Model 3 in Table 2 supports H5 ( $b_7 < 0$  and  $b_8 > 0$ ). That some parties stay close to the average party system agenda may help to explain why they are in fact large mainstream parties and often part of the governing coalition, but demonstrating this characteristic empirically is nevertheless an important extension of our understanding of the role of avoidance and engagement in parties' issue competition. In particular, the estimated effect of the agenda variable differs between mainstream parties and other parties in the party system. This is illustrated in Figure 1.

**Figure 1: Predicted Effects of the Party System Agenda for Different Party Types**

*Note:* Predicted effects calculated based on estimates from Model 3 in Table 2. The dashed lines represent 95 per cent confidence intervals.

In order to further evaluate the importance of the agenda component we performed a number of additional tests. First, and most important, we introduced the alternative indicator of the party system agenda based on annual measures of the length of debates in parliament. This is a way to measure the agenda component closer in time to a given election than the measure based on the previous election. Hence, building on the logic of decomposing the sources of a correlation (see Rosenberg, 1968) we expect the introduction of this intermediate variable to reduce the direct effect of the manifesto-based measure of the party system agenda. What such elimination tells us is that the party system agenda at the election before matters *because* it is reflected in the party system agenda that is formed after the election and before the next election. Parties are not expected to respond to issues just because other parties focused on them at the last election three or four years ago. Rather, they respond because they still perceive certain issues as important and other issues as less important.

The results of this re-estimation are shown in Table 3. Model 1, which is identical to model 1 in Table 2, is our baseline model and is included to evaluate the contribution from adding the parliamentary-based measure of the party system agenda. Two noteworthy results appear from Table 3. First, the issue attention of a given party at the previous election remains largely unaffected by the inclusion of the parliamentary agenda variable corroborating the idea of a stable and party-specific component in parties' issue emphases. Second, as expected, the parliamentary debate variable has a clear and positive effect on a

**Table 3: Statistical Analyses of Parties' Issue Attention (including the Parliamentary Agenda)**

|                                                    | <i>Model 1</i> | <i>Model 2</i> | <i>Model 3</i> |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|
| Constant                                           | 1.38*** (0.39) | −0.13 (0.26)   | 0.09 (0.28)    |
| Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>                 | 0.28*** (0.02) | 0.24*** (0.02) | 0.26*** (0.02) |
| Agenda <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>                          | 0.39*** (0.03) | 0.20*** (0.03) | 0.21*** (0.03) |
| Parliamentary agenda <sub>i,t-k</sub>              | —              | 0.59*** (0.04) | 0.51*** (0.05) |
| Party type (mainstream = 1, others = 0)            | —              | —              | −0.56* (0.27)  |
| Party type × Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>    | —              | —              | −0.07* (0.03)  |
| Party type × Parliamentary agenda <sub>i,t-k</sub> | —              | —              | 0.20*** (0.06) |
| Level 1 N (issue)                                  | 24             | 24             | 24             |
| Variance Level 1                                   | 1.79           | 0.99           | 1.00           |
| N Total                                            | 3,666          | 3,450          | 3,450          |

*Note:* Coefficients are unstandardized results from a restricted maximum likelihood multilevel random effects model. Standard errors in parentheses. Subscript<sub>t-k</sub> refers to the year before the election whereas subscript<sub>t-1</sub> refers to the previous election (hence:  $k < 1$ ). \* $p < 0.05$ . \*\* $p < 0.01$ . \*\*\* $p < 0.001$  (two-sided).

party's issue attention at the upcoming election. In combination with the reduced effect of the lagged campaign agenda measure this result not only demonstrates the importance of the agenda component for understanding a party's issue attention, but it also suggests that campaign agendas matter exactly because they correlate with parliamentary agendas between election campaigns.<sup>14</sup>

### ***Robustness and Additional Analysis***

We conclude the analysis with a closer look at the robustness of the estimated results.<sup>15</sup> First, since some research on issue variation tends to show that the major economic issues perform differently than other issues (see Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2010; 272–3), we re-ran the analyses excluding the two major economic issues (economy/taxation and labor market) in order to see how this affects the results. All estimated coefficients retain their direction and statistical significance, including the interaction terms, which implies that in this case our cross-issue time-series modeling does not hide important issue heterogeneity (results available from the authors upon request). We also performed a similar jackknife strategy with respect to elections and parties, leaving out one election and one party at a time and then re-estimating the models. In very few cases does the effect of non-bloc party agendas and one of the interaction effects approach the border of statistical non-significance, but the general impression from these re-estimations is a high degree of robustness of the main results reported in Tables 2 and 3 above.<sup>16</sup>

Second, we explored the important question of causality between a party's issue attention and the common issue agenda in a set of Direct Granger (non-)causality tests (see Freeman, 1983). This supplementary analysis produced two noteworthy findings (the results are summarized in Table A3 in the Appendix): it corroborates the underlying assumption of the statistical analyses that the direction of causality runs mainly from the

common agenda to the agenda of the individual parties; and it shows that even when allowing for instantaneous correlation between the agenda and the issue emphasis of individual parties we still see an effect of the lagged election agenda on a party's issue emphasis at time  $t$ .

Third, we explored the consequences of our coding of party types in more detail. We examined whether the effect of the large mainstream party variable changes if we include two minor mainstream parties, the Social Liberals (*Radikale*) and Socialist People's Party (*Socialistisk Folkeparti*), in the category of mainstream parties. This re-categorization did not substantially change the interaction effects found in Tables 2 and 3, but it did reduce the estimated differences between mainstream parties and other parties. This modification suggests that the category of relatively *large* mainstream parties (in Denmark: Conservatives, Liberals and Social Democrats) in this respect actually does represent a more distinct group of parties. We also turned the party type measure upside down and constructed a dummy variable taking the value '1' if clearly a niche party, otherwise '0'.<sup>17</sup> Replacing the dummy for large mainstream parties with this niche party dummy we thus expect to see the opposite interaction effects to those presented in Tables 2 and 3. We do find exactly this. Niche parties respond less to the agenda of other parties and show a more stable issue attention profile across elections than other parties.

Fourth, we examined responsiveness to non-bloc parties in more detail by subdividing the agenda of the non-bloc parties into main competitor parties agenda, and agenda of potential coalition partners. The underlying idea is that this separation helps us understand why political parties respond to the agenda of non-bloc parties. As explained above, the center parties in the Danish party system (Social Liberals, Centre Democrats and Socialist People's Party) have sometimes changed bloc, and responsiveness to non-bloc parties may in fact be responsiveness to these parties and not to the main competitor from the other bloc. However, for both center-left and center-right parties the additional analyses show that mainstream parties actually respond to both their main competitor as well as to the potential coalition partners. Thus, responsiveness to non-bloc parties is not just responsiveness to potential coalition partners (results are not shown, but are available from the authors upon request).

Furthermore, inspired by recent research on the differences between opposition and government parties (Bawn and Somer-Topcu, 2012; Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2010) as well as significant research on mainstream and niche parties (see above) we pushed the analysis further in order to learn more about, for instance, different responses of mainstream parties to niche parties that steal votes from them compared to other niche parties, and different responses to the common agenda dependent on government or opposition status. However, the results of these additional explorations do not seem as robust as the results reported in Tables 2 and 3 above, and the impression is that one would need observations from more party systems in order to pursue these mechanisms further.

Finally, including the results of the last election suggests that if government parties have gained seats in the last election, their issue attention at the next election is less affected by the common agenda and more affected by their own agenda at the previous election. Winning an election thus seems to mean sticking more with your own issues.

## Conclusion

To advance our understanding of issue competition between political parties, this article has, first of all, set up a framework for understanding the interaction between parties in issue competition. The idea of a party-specific component and an agenda component provides the basic element of this framework and suggests that issue competition is a question about issue avoidance *and* engagement – and not about either avoidance or engagement. Second, on this foundation the framework allowed us to begin asking and examining hitherto neglected questions about which parties respond to which other parties in issue competition. Our analysis thus revealed a distinct ‘party bloc effect’ in the sense that parties are more responsive to the issue campaigns of parties from the same party bloc than of other parties. It is important to stress, however, that parties still respond to the issue attention of parties from the other party bloc. Thus, the finding that parties respond to other parties’ issue agenda is not just driven by the fact that some of these parties belong to the same party bloc.

Rather than providing final answers to the questions raised in this article, the framework of issue competition is intended to provide a theoretical basis for further investigation. One question that stands out for further research is the relationship between a party’s issue attention and external factors like media attention, real world events or public salience. John Sides (2006), for instance, argues that the issue attention of candidates in American congressional elections to some extent can be understood as a response to public salience of issues alongside the issue ownership of the parties to which the candidates belong. Thus, a central question for further research is to what extent the agenda component reflects the fact that all parties think they have to respond to issues receiving significant attention in the media or which are highly salient with the public. The reverse causality, however, is also very likely – namely that issues that receive a lot of attention from political parties also become subject to media attention and become salient among the general public (see, e.g., Bennett, 1990). Furthermore, even if the agenda component to some extent reflects a reaction to external factors, the findings that issues on the common agenda become subject to inter-party competition cannot be explained by the classic accounts which claim that selective emphasis and issue avoidance are the rule rather than the exception in issue competition.

A further question relates to how issue competition is related to positional or spatial competition. Parties can address the same issues but still offer very different policy positions, so issue overlap may in fact be the result of intense positional competition. It may also be driven by another positional strategy – namely ‘issue ambiguity’, which has been shown to be electorally beneficial (Tomz and Van Houweling, 2008). Issue overlap may thus result from parties offering ‘ambiguous’ issue positions to the electorate.

A final group of questions relates to the role of mainstream parties in interparty competition. For these parties, the agenda component plays a more important role than it does for niche parties. Bonnie Meguid (2005) focuses on the positional strategies that mainstream parties apply when they take up an issue and the electoral consequences for niche parties. However, what makes mainstream parties take up an issue raised by niche parties in the first place is not really explored beyond arguing that niche parties suffer

electorally when mainstream parties dismiss their preferred issue. Understanding when mainstream parties take up issues seems a crucial element in understanding the dynamics of issue competition.

In general, there are still many questions about issue competition left unexplored. This article offers a theoretical platform from which to study these questions.

## Appendix

**Table A1: Topics and Descriptors**

| <i>Issue</i>                    | <i>Manifestos<sup>a</sup></i> | <i>Parliamentary debate<sup>b</sup></i> |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Economy and taxation            | 28.12 (17.66)                 | 21.48 (8.34)                            |
| Personal rights                 | 2.55 (4.27)                   | 1.59 (1.01)                             |
| Danish National Church          | 0.15 (0.83)                   | 0.45 (0.37)                             |
| Refugees and immigrants         | 1.68 (4.54)                   | 2.16 (2.58)                             |
| Health                          | 2.16 (4.19)                   | 3.97 (1.91)                             |
| Agriculture                     | 2.17 (3.88)                   | 4.72 (2.11)                             |
| Labor market                    | 10.62 (10.42)                 | 6.76 (2.42)                             |
| Education                       | 6.64 (7.32)                   | 5.56 (1.77)                             |
| Culture and sports              | 0.86 (1.92)                   | 2.20 (1.26)                             |
| Environment                     | 3.07 (4.52)                   | 4.24 (3.08)                             |
| Energy                          | 1.21 (2.96)                   | 2.24 (2.10)                             |
| Transportation                  | 0.99 (2.13)                   | 4.59 (1.57)                             |
| Justice and crime               | 2.04 (3.64)                   | 3.58 (1.75)                             |
| Social affairs                  | 8.49 (7.56)                   | 6.04 (2.00)                             |
| Housing                         | 6.96 (8.32)                   | 5.81 (2.28)                             |
| Business                        | 3.63 (4.10)                   | 5.46 (1.84)                             |
| Defense                         | 5.59 (7.65)                   | 3.03 (2.15)                             |
| Technology and communication    | 0.86 (2.06)                   | 2.22 (1.17)                             |
| Foreign affairs                 | 5.06 (6.24)                   | 4.27 (1.87)                             |
| EU                              | 2.21 (6.11)                   | 2.66 (2.65)                             |
| Regional and local affairs      | 0.59 (2.20)                   | 1.59 (1.11)                             |
| Public sector                   | 1.51 (2.63)                   | 2.05 (1.12)                             |
| Control of government           | 2.82 (8.75)                   | 1.59 (1.33)                             |
| Greenland and the Faroe Islands | 0.04 (0.24)                   | 1.74 (1.00)                             |

*Note:* <sup>a</sup>Cells contain means (percentages) across all parties and elections with standard deviations in parentheses. <sup>b</sup>Cells contain means (percentages) across all parliamentary sessions with standard deviations in parentheses.

**Table A2: Parties and Descriptors**

| <i>Party</i>             | <i>Length of manifestos<sup>a</sup></i> | <i>Average number of issues addressed in each party manifesto<sup>b</sup></i> |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Social Democrats         | 179 (221)                               | 12 (3.7)                                                                      |
| Social Liberals          | 74 (55)                                 | 11 (3.8)                                                                      |
| Conservatives            | 99 (61)                                 | 12 (3.9)                                                                      |
| Centre Democrats         | 180 (276)                               | 12 (4.9)                                                                      |
| Justice Party            | 59 (51)                                 | 10 (3.4)                                                                      |
| Socialist People's Party | 217 (149)                               | 13 (4.0)                                                                      |
| Communist Party          | 80 (64)                                 | 9 (2.3)                                                                       |
| Danish People's Party    | 35 (23)                                 | 13 (2.1)                                                                      |
| Christian Democrats      | 175 (244)                               | 14 (3.4)                                                                      |
| Liberal Party            | 122 (127)                               | 11 (3.4)                                                                      |
| Red-Green Alliance       | 120 (36)                                | 15 (1.7)                                                                      |
| Left Socialists          | 102 (49)                                | 11 (2.8)                                                                      |
| Progress Party           | 152 (124)                               | 12 (4.4)                                                                      |

*Note:* <sup>a</sup>Cells contain average length of manifestos (in sentences) across all elections with standard deviations in parentheses. <sup>b</sup>Cells contain mean number of issues addressed in the manifesto across all elections with standard deviations in parentheses.

**Table A3: Direct Granger (Non-Causality) Tests**

| <i>Agenda<sub>i,p</sub> → Issue attention<sub>i,p</sub></i>                                       |                | <i>Issue attention<sub>i,p</sub> → Agenda<sub>i,p</sub></i>                                       |                |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| Agenda <sub>i,p,t</sub>                                                                           | 0.50*** (0.04) | Issue attention <sub>i,p,t</sub>                                                                  | 0.10*** (0.01) |
| Agenda <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>                                                                         | 0.11** (0.04)  | Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>                                                                | 0.01 (0.01)    |
| Agenda <sub>i,p,t-2</sub>                                                                         | 0.02 (0.03)    | Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-2</sub>                                                                | 0.01 (0.01)    |
| Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>                                                                | 0.20*** (0.02) | Agenda <sub>i,p,t-1</sub>                                                                         | 0.40*** (0.02) |
| Issue attention <sub>i,p,t-2</sub>                                                                | 0.15*** (0.02) | Agenda <sub>i,p,t-2</sub>                                                                         | 0.23*** (0.02) |
| <i>p</i> -values of X <sup>2</sup> test of H <sub>0</sub><br>(H <sub>0</sub> = Lag 1 + Lag 2 = 0) | 12.63**        | <i>p</i> -values of X <sup>2</sup> test of H <sub>0</sub><br>(H <sub>0</sub> = Lag 1 + Lag 2 = 0) | 4.95           |

*Note:* \**p* < 0.05. \*\**p* < 0.01. \*\*\**p* < 0.001. (two-sided). *N* = 3,245.

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## Notes

Earlier versions of this paper have been presented at the Department of Political Science and Government, Aarhus University; the Comparative Policy Agendas Conference, The Hague, 2009; the ECPR General Conference, Potsdam, 2009; MPSA, 2010; and the ESF-sponsored workshop on political parties and policy agendas at the University of Manchester, 2010. Thanks to the participants at these various occasions for many constructive comments.

- 1 The manifestos were originally collected by the late Tove-Lise Schou and kindly given to us by Robert Klemmensen and Martin Ejnar Hansen. Unfortunately, manifestos for the Christian People's Party 1971, the Conservatives 1984 and the Progress Party 1988 are missing.
- 2 For an introduction to the American coding system, see <http://www.policyagendas.org>.
- 3 Calculating relative measures of attention is in accord with the standard approach within the issue competition literature (Sigelman and Buell, 2004, p. 652). The main problem with using the absolute number of sentences is that the length of party manifestos varies across parties and across elections, which means that changes in the absolute number of sentences devoted to an issue might reflect a change of format rather than a change in party priorities. Furthermore, the relative measure of attention is better aligned with the classic assumption of issue competition – namely that the parties have to prioritize their attention and that they cannot just pay attention to everything.
- 4 Since some of the parties have been present from 1953 to 2007 and others emerged later in the period, the number of elections per party varies in this sample between a minimum of two and a maximum of 20.
- 5 Since Danish governments are typically minority governments not all parties from a bloc are actually in government.
- 6 In Denmark, there is no fixed election cycle. The Prime Minister just has to call elections every four years. The time between elections therefore varies.
- 7 It would in principle be possible to break each debate into how many columns were expressed by MPs from various parties, but this coding does not exist and it would be questionable whether it reflected the selective issue emphasis of individual parties. There is no *a priori* distribution of speaking time in parliament that favors certain parties.
- 8 One concern when using *levels* may be problems with non-stationarity in the time-series, but performing a set of Fisher type tests for unit roots (or stationarity) do not show evidence of non-stationarity in these series. Another concern is auto-correlation, which we handle by the inclusion of a lagged dependent variable.
- 9 Results are available from the authors upon request.
- 10 Intra-class (IC) correlations vary between  $IC \approx 2.35^{-19}$  and  $IC \approx 2.19^{-21}$ . Note that the low ICs at the manifesto level also imply that the use of relative shares of issue attention does not produce correlated errors within manifestos. The choice of a random effects estimation was corroborated by the fact that the null hypothesis underlying the Hausman (1978) test could not be rejected in any of the post estimations.
- 11 Without covariates, this random intercept model of *issue attention*<sub>i,p,t</sub> can be expressed as *issue attention*<sub>i,p,t</sub> =  $\beta + \zeta_i + \epsilon_{i,p,t}$ .  $\zeta_i$  is the random deviation of issue *i*'s mean measurement from the overall mean  $\beta$ , whereas the component  $\epsilon_{i,p,t}$  is the random deviation of *issue attention*<sub>i,p,t</sub> from issue *i*'s mean. See also Rabe-Hesketh and Skrondal (2008, p. 55).
- 12 All main analyses have been re-estimated using a tobit approach and, as expected, this does not alter any of the main conclusions. Results available from the authors upon request.
- 13 A Wald test for  $b_4 > b_5$  yields  $X^2 = 38.7$ ,  $p < 0.0001$  (one-tailed).
- 14 Including the parliamentary agenda measured two years before the election produces similar, but as expected, weaker effects. Going back to three years before the election is problematic in the Danish context with no fixed election cycle. Thus, in some periods, there have not been more than two years between elections.
- 15 We owe thanks to the three anonymous reviewers for their helpful suggestions of many of these additional analyses.
- 16 Adding a time counter to control for trends over time does not challenge this conclusion either. Interacting the time counter with the main variables indicates that responsiveness to the common agenda declines slightly over the years, which is an effect that might be worth exploring in future research. We also included a dummy variable measuring before and after the 1973 Danish landslide election, but this variable was not statistically significant.
- 17 As clear niche parties, we coded the nationalist parties (*Dansk Folkeparti* and *Fremskridtspartiet*), the extreme left parties (*Enhedslisten* and *Venstresocialisterne*) as well as the Christian party (*Kristeligt Folkeparti*), which was established in reaction to the issue of free abortion in the early 1970s. See also Wagner (2012).

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